

The Best Places to Eat Jerk Chicken

The Pork Pit inexpensive

You'll find plenty of food options among the character-packed beach restaurants, bars, and rum-and-seafood shacks of Montego Bay. But for those who seek the very best in jerk chicken, there is only one place to go – the Pork Pit, near Walter Fletcher Beach. A favorite haunt of beach-goers, who descend on its outdoor tables en masse at noon, the Pork Pit serves a large lunch of melt-in-the-mouth jerk meat (not just pork but poultry and seafood as well), corn cobs, and baked yams at shoestring prices. Delightfully informal with a seemingly unlimited supply of bottled Red Stripe beer, the Pork Pit favors plastic cutlery and throwaway plates over fancy tableware and simply lets the food speak for itself. Marvel at the guys in neon-yellow Pork Pit T-shirts as they carve up the jerk with gusto onto old iron griddles amid considerable smoke and sizzle.

27 Gloucester Avenue, Montego Bay; open 11 AM–11 PM daily; (876) 940 3008

In Kingston

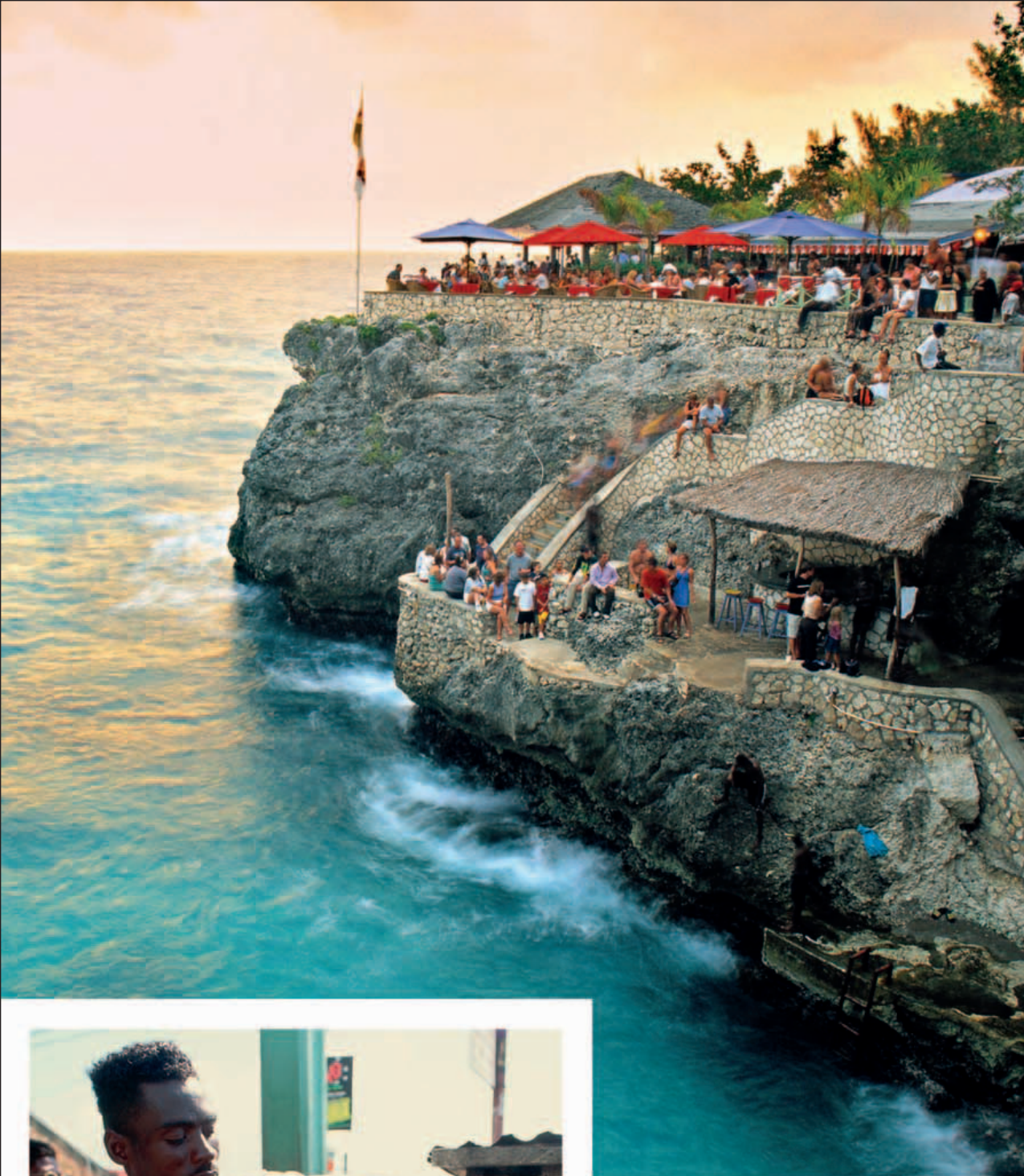
Head to the **Chelsea Jerk Centre (876 926 6322; inexpensive)** on Kingston's Chelsea Avenue for an urban take on this Jamaican food favorite. Jerk chicken, pork, and seafood come with old-style corn fritters. True jerk aficionados also rave about **Our Place (876 927 7886; inexpensive)** on Hope Road, where locals trade tales over a sweet-smelling jerk pit with an after-work beer. Unmarked and tucked away among the billboards of the commercial district, this secret hideaway boasts blissful anonymity away from the jostle of the fast-paced city.

Also in Jamaica

The most relaxed place to try piquant jerk ribs is **Ocho Rios Jerk Centre (876 974 2549; inexpensive)** on Da Costa Drive, Ocho Rios. This delightfully rustic open-air jerk joint is one of Kingston's finest. Daily specials are posted on a chalkboard menu. Beers are frosted, the rum is strong, and the exotic array of fresh fruit juices are thirst-quenchingly good.

Around the World

In the UK, British-Jamaican reggae musician, chef, entrepreneur, and record producer Levi Roots brings plenty of spicy passion to his restaurant **Papine Jerk Centre (www.100acres.com/papinejerk; inexpensive)** in Wandsworth, South London. Using lip-smacking, zingy marinades to spice up chicken, fish, and simple cuts of meat, Roots – the man behind “Reggae Reggae Sauce” – creates authentic mouthwatering West Indian cuisine. You can't miss the restaurant – it's decked out in the bright Jamaican colors of yellow, red, and green. Drop in, swap gossip, and eat great-tasting jerk.



Above Jerk chicken is usually served with char-grilled corn or *tostones* (fried green plantains) and rice mixed with beans

Left Some of the best jerk chicken in Jamaica comes from street sellers at the roadside or in “jerk shacks” around the island